

Chapter 6

Postmodernism, contemporary popular culture and recent theoretical developments

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THIS CHAPTER WILL consider the postmodernist analysis of contemporary popular culture. Like the preceding chapters, it will assess critically the claims it makes. However, unlike them it will be even more concerned with the empirical arguments of postmodernism. One reason for this is that postmodern theory and post-structuralism, its theoretical and philosophical foundation, are relatively recent developments, and still less familiar than the other theories discussed: for example, there are few sources which present clear and readable accounts of postmodern theory. Compounding this problem, much of the debate about postmodernism has been too vague, abstract and difficult to understand. Compared with this theoretical output, relatively little has been said about postmodernism as an empirical or historical phenomenon.

Postmodernism has attracted increasing interest and attention in recent years. This can readily be seen by the book titles published using the term or its equivalents, or making clear their concern with postmodernism. The *Books in Print* index shows no book titles published on postmodernism between 1978 and 1981, but 14 published in 1988, 22 in 1989 and 29 in 1990. The *Humanities Index* shows no book titles or books on postmodernism published between 1980 and 1983, but a total of 241 appearing between 1987 and 1991.¹ This does not include books which are not specifically concerned with postmodernism but still discuss it, nor journal articles or coverage in the more popular media. Yet even here two major journals in the social and cultural sciences, *Theory, Culture and Society* and *Screen*, have devoted special issues to postmodernism,² while arts programmes have considered the major themes raised by the debate or looked at specific areas, such as architecture. Indeed, in the United Kingdom postmodernism is now a term commonly used about contemporary architecture.³

Despite this, relatively little has been said about whether postmodernism is on the rise in contemporary societies; if anything, it is assumed, almost without argument, to be

already here. Most discussion seems more involved with the theory of postmodernism than with its empirical appearance. Relatively few contributors have asked the question: can we see postmodernism in the world around us? The tendency has been to assume rather than argue that it has become widespread in modern societies; and less attention has been devoted to showing this is the case.⁴ In turn, this has been matched by the excessive attention given to the problem of defining the term itself.⁵

This chapter will look at postmodernist theory and the extent to which postmodernism can be identified empirically in modern societies, popular culture and the mass media being special areas of concern in the debate about postmodernism.⁶ This focus on the empirical detection of postmodernism means that the chapter will answer the following questions: What is postmodernism? Can it be identified in contemporary popular media culture? What are some of the reasons advanced for its emergence? and What critique can be developed of its arguments?

What is postmodernism?

There are a number of points—those most heavily stressed in the literature—which can be used to define postmodernism.⁷ This definition is something of a composite picture, but it is accurate enough for this chapter.

Culture and society

First, the argument is that postmodernism describes the emergence of a society in which the mass media and popular culture are the most important and powerful institutions, and control and shape all other types of social relationships. Popular cultural signs and media images increasingly dominate our sense of reality, and the way we define ourselves and the world around us. Postmodern theory is an attempt to understand a media-saturated society. For example, the mass media were once thought to hold a mirror up to a

wider social reality, and thereby reflect it. Now reality can only be defined by the surface reflections of this mirror. Society has become subsumed Within the mass media. It is no longer even a question of the media distorting reality, since this implies there is a reality, outside the surface simulations of the media, which can be distorted; and this is precisely what is at issue according to postmodern theory.

In a way, this idea comes from one of the directions taken by media and cultural theory. To put it simply, the liberal view argued that the media held up a mirror to, and thereby reflected in a fairly accurate manner, a wider social reality. The radical rejoinder to this insisted that this mirror distorted rather than reflected reality. Subsequently, a more abstract and conceptual media and cultural theory suggested that the media played some part in constructing our sense of social reality, and our sense of being a part of this reality (Curran *et al.* 1982; Bennett 1982). It is a relatively short step from this (and one which need not be taken) to the proposition that only the media can constitute our sense of reality. To return to the original metaphor, it is claimed that this mirror is now the only reality we have.

An aspect of this is the idea that in the postmodern condition it becomes more difficult to distinguish the economy from popular culture. Consumption—what we buy and what determines what we buy—is increasingly influenced by popular culture because popular culture increasingly determines consumption. For example, we watch more films because of the extended ownership of VCRs, while advertising, which makes increasing use of popular cultural references, plays a more important role in deciding what we will buy.

An emphasis on style at the expense of substance

A crucial implication of the first point is that in a postmodern world, surfaces and style become ever more important, producing and feeding off what is called a 'designer ideology'. Or as Harvey puts it: 'images dominate narrative' (1989:347–

348). The argument is that we increasingly consume images and signs for their own sake rather than for their 'usefulness' or for the deeper values they may represent. Images and signs are consumed precisely because they are images and signs, regardless of questions of utility and value. This is thought to be evident in popular culture itself where surface and style, playfulness and jokes, and what things look like, are said to predominate at the expense of content, substance and meaning. As a result, qualities such as artistic merit, integrity, seriousness, authenticity, realism, intellectual depth and strong narratives tend to be undermined. Moreover, virtual reality computer graphics can allow people to experience various forms of reality at second hand, potentially at least as surface simulations rather than real events.

Art and popular culture

If the first two points are accepted it follows that for postmodern culture anything can be turned into a joke, reference or quotation in its eclectic play of styles, simulations and surfaces. If popular cultural signs and media images are taking over in defining our sense of reality for us, and if this means that style takes precedence over content, then it becomes more difficult to maintain a meaningful distinction between art and popular culture. There are no longer any agreed and inviolable criteria which can serve to differentiate art from popular culture. Compare this with the fears of the mass culture critics that mass culture would eventually subvert high culture. The only difference seems to be that these critics were pessimistic about such developments, whereas some, but not all, postmodern theorists are by contrast optimistic.

A good example of what postmodernist theory is getting at is provided by Andy Warhol's multi-image print of Leonardo Da Vinci's famous painting, the *Mona Lisa*. This example of pop art echoes Walter Benjamin's (1973) argument (see above), as well as an earlier and similarly comical version of the same painting by Marcel Duchamp (McShine 1989). The print

shows that the uniqueness, the artistic aura, of the *Mona Lisa* is destroyed by its infinite reproducibility through the silk-screen printing technique employed by Warhol. Instead, it is turned into a joke—the print's title is *Thirty are better than One*. This point is underlined by the fact that Warhol was renowned for his prints of famous popular cultural icons, such as Marilyn Monroe and Elvis Presley, and of everyday consumer items, such as tins of Campbell's soup, Coca-Cola bottles and dollar bills.

Another aspect of this process is that art becomes increasingly integrated into the economy because it is used to encourage people to consume through the expanded role it plays in advertising, and because it becomes a commercial good in its own right. Also, postmodern popular culture refuses to respect the pretensions and distinctiveness of art. Therefore, the breakdown of the distinction between art and popular culture, as well as crossovers between the two, become more prevalent.

Confusions over time and space

This point argues that present and future expansions, constrictions and concentrations of time and space have led to increasing confusion and incoherence in social senses of space and time, in our maps of the places where we live, and our ideas about the times by which we organise our lives. The title and narrative of the *Back to the Future* films capture this point fairly well. The growing immediacy of global space and time resulting from the dominance of the mass media means that previously unified and coherent ideas about space and time begin to be undermined, and become distorted and confused. Rapid international flows of capital, money, information and culture disrupt the linear unities of time, and the established distances of geographical space. Because of the speed and scope of modern mass communications, and the relative ease and rapidity with which people and information can travel, time and space become less stable and comprehensible, and more confused and incoherent (Harvey 1989:part 3).

Postmodern popular culture is seen to express these confusions and distortions. As such, it is less likely to reflect coherent senses of space or time. Some idea of this argument can be obtained by trying to identify the locations used in some pop videos, the narratives of some recent films, or the times and spaces crossed in a typical evening of television viewing. In short, postmodern popular culture is a culture *sans frontières*, outside history.

The decline of metanarratives

The loss of a sense of history as a continuous, linear narrative, a clear sequence of events, is indicative of the argument that meta-narratives are in decline in the postmodern world. This point follows on from the previous arguments we have noted. Meta-narratives are ideas such as religion, science, art, modernism and Marxism which make absolute, universal and all-embracing claims to knowledge and truth. Postmodern theory is highly sceptical about these metanarratives, and argues that they are disintegrating, losing their validity and legitimacy and increasingly prone to criticism. It is argued that it is becoming increasingly difficult for people to organise and interpret their lives in the light of meta-narratives of whatever kind. This argument would therefore be relevant, for example, to the declining significance of religion as a metanarrative in postmodern societies. Postmodernism has been particularly critical of the metanarrative of Marxism and its claim to absolute truth, as it has been of any theory which tries to read a pattern of progress into history. In short, its argument is that metanarratives are in decline.⁸

The consequence of this is that postmodernism rejects the claim of any theory to absolute knowledge, or the demand of any social practice to universal validity. So, for example, on the one hand, there are movements in the natural or hard sciences away from deterministic and absolute metanarratives towards more contingent and probabilistic claims to the truth, while on the other hand people appear to be moving away from the metanarrative of life-long, monogamous marriage

towards a series of discrete if still monogamous 'relationships' (Harvey 1989:9; Lash and Urry 1987:298). The diverse, iconoclastic, referential and collage-like character of postmodern popular culture clearly draws inspiration from the decline of metanarratives.

Contemporary popular culture and postmodernism

We now need to look more closely at some examples of popular culture to see if the existence of postmodernism can be detected. Clearly, what follows is by no means systematic or exhaustive. It is necessarily selective and designed to search for some elements and trends in popular culture in order to provide a preliminary assessment of the problems posed. It should help clarify the nature of postmodernism.

Architecture

This is a particularly appropriate example to use because, during the twentieth century, groups of architects have identified themselves as 'modernist' or 'postmodernist'. These terms have also been used to describe contemporary buildings.⁹ The argument here is that modernism in architecture, which first came to prominence in the 1920s, based itself upon a radical rejection of all previous forms of architecture, and insisted that buildings and architecture have to be created anew according to rational and scientific principles. Functionality and efficiency, high rise, streamlined, glass and concrete structures, and a disregard for the past and for context, have all become its trademark. It has sought to reflect, celebrate and entrench the dynamism of industrial modernity through the rational, scientific and technical construction of built space.

Postmodernism in architecture rejects this metanarrative. Its hallmarks are: highly ornate, elaborately designed, contextualised and brightly coloured buildings; a stress on fictionality and playfulness; and the mixing of styles drawn

from different historical periods in almost random and eclectic designs. Postmodernism turns buildings into celebrations of style and surface, using architecture to make jokes about built space. Examples of this include Philip Johnson's grandfather clock-shaped building for AT&T in New York, Charles Moore's Piazza Italia in New Orleans, or Richard Rogers's Lloyds building in the City of London. Rather than build or design according to rational, scientific principles, postmodern architecture is said to proceed according to the context in which the building is to be placed, and to mix together styles, for example classical (ancient Roman or Greek) with vernacular (popular cultural signs and icons). It embraces cultural definitions and the superiority of style, bringing together ideas and forms from different times and places. It also rejects the privileged metanarrative of modernist architecture, and the distinction drawn between classical and modernist architecture as art and vernacular architecture as popular culture. For example, Las Vegas has been seen as an exemplar of and inspiration for postmodern architecture (Venturi *et al.* 1977).

Cinema

Postmodern theory clearly holds what it considers important arguments about visual phenomena, and the most obvious films in which to look for signs of postmodernism are those which emphasise style, spectacle, special effects and images, at the expense of content, character, substance, narrative and social comment. Examples include films such as *Dick Tracey* (1990) or *9½ Weeks* (1986). But to look only at films which deliberately avoid realism and sell themselves on their surface qualities can obscure some of the other things which are going on in contemporary cinema.¹⁰ The films directed and produced by Steven Spielberg and his associates, such as the *Indiana Jones* (1981, 1984 and 1989) and *Back to the Future* series (1985, 1989 and 1990), equally display elements of postmodernism. This is not only because of their style but because their major points of reference, and the sources they

most frequently invoke, are earlier forms of popular culture such as cartoons, 'B' feature science-fiction films, and the Saturday morning, movie-house, adventure series people of Spielberg's generation would have viewed in their youth. It is likewise argued that these films appear to stress spectacle and action through their use of sophisticated techniques and relentless pursuit sequences, rather than the complexities and nuances of clever plotting and character development. Sometimes it is suggested that the narrative demands of classical realism are being increasingly ignored by postmodern cinema. Moreover, the *Back to the Future* series and other films such as *Brazil* (1985) and *Blue Velvet* (1986) are said to be postmodern because of the way they are based on confusions over time and space. Others, such as *Who Framed Roger Rabbit?* (1988), can be seen to be postmodern because of their deliberate use of distinct (cultural and technical) genres: the cartoon strip and the detective story. Yet others, such as *Body Heat* (1981), can be claimed to be postmodern because they are parasitic on the cinema's past, recycling—in this example—the crime thriller of the 1940s. They thus engage in a kind of 'retro-nostalgia'. Related to this are films which recycle themselves in a number of sequels once the magic box office formula has been discovered, such as the *Rocky* (1976, 1979, 1982, 1985 and 1990) or *Rambo* (1982, 1985 and 1988) films and the many other repeats which could be mentioned. This tendency is argued to be postmodern partly because it ignores the demands of artistic originality and novelty associated with modernism. But mainly, it is argued to be postmodern because it goes no further than recycling the recent past, making films which are merely imitations of other films rather than reflections of social reality.

A frequently cited example of the postmodern film is *Blade Runner* (1982) (Harvey 1989: chapter 18; Instrell 1992). Among the more noticeable characteristics of this film (which is about Los Angeles in the early part of the twenty-first century), we can note how its architectural look, or production design, clearly mixes styles from different periods. The buildings

which house the major corporation have lighting characteristic of contemporary skyscrapers but the overall look of ancient temples, while the 'street talk' consists of words and phrases taken from a whole range of distinct languages. These architectural and linguistic confusions can be said to contribute to an elusive sense of time since we appear to be in the past, the present and the future at the same time. It is a science fiction film which is not obviously futuristic in its design. This effect is accentuated in two ways. First, the 'non-human humans' in the film are not mechanical robots but 'replicants', almost perfect simulations of human beings. Second, the genre of the film is not clear.¹¹ It has been defined as a science fiction film, but it is also a detective film. Its story unfolds as a detective story, the hero has many of the character traits we associate with the 'tough-guy' policeman or private investigator, and his voice-over, which relates the investigation, draws upon the idioms and tone of film noir.

Television

One way of considering television as an example of postmodernism is to see it as a postmodern medium in its own right. Television's regular daily and night-time flows of images and information bring together bits and pieces from elsewhere, and create its sequences of programmes on the basis of compilations and surface simulations. Equally, there are a number of instructive examples of television programmes which can be used to assess the emergence of postmodernism. One useful example is the police and crime series *Miami Vice* (1985–1990), although its distinguishing features may be found elsewhere.¹² There are many other examples of television programmes which could be used to assess the claims of postmodernist theory, such as the surreal cult series *Twin Peaks* (1990–1991) and *Wild Palms* (1993).

One of the most important claims made about *Miami Vice* is that it was heavily reliant upon style and surface. Commentators have noted its visual 'sense' and striking imagery, pointing to the overall look and ambience which the

series managed to achieve. For example, its executive producer, Michael Mann—who subsequently went on to produce the even more ‘hyper-real’ *Crime Story* (1989)—when asked once about the main rule he worked to when making the programme, is reputed to have replied, ‘no earth tones’.¹³ The series was carefully projected by its colour, locations and camera work. When it first came on in America, one critical response was to suggest it didn’t conform to normal television. This refers to the way it seemed more in keeping with the grander stylistic and adventurous conventions of cinema rather than the cosy, intimate and more ‘realistic’ routines of television. It was noticeably different from more seemingly realistic police series such as *Hill Street Blues* (1981–1989). It has also been compared with film noir. This visual appeal was crucial to the series and was added to by the designer clothes worn by its detective heroes, and the imaginative day and night-time images of Miami. The visual pleasures derived from style and ‘look’—locations, settings, people, clothes, interiors, the city—were a crucial motivation in the making and appreciation of the series. The use of an obtrusive pop and rock music sound track added to these pleasures, representing something of a departure for the police and crime series. More than this, it did not so much reject narrative as such, but rather parodied and stylised the established conventions of the genre, while abounding with self-conscious references to popular culture. For example, the conventions of the gangster film were often parodied, while one episode was a more or less straightforward remake of the western *High Noon* (1952).

Advertising

This example is drawn from television advertising, and can be used as another way to try to exemplify the emergence of postmodernism in contemporary popular culture. The argument here is that advertisements used to tell us how valuable and useful a product was. However, they now say less about the product directly, and are more concerned with

sending up or parodying advertising itself by citing other adverts, by using references drawn from popular culture and by self-consciously making clear their status as advertisements. This argument recognises that advertising is always involved in selling things to people, but suggests that these features distinguish those elements of postmodernism which can be found in contemporary television advertising.

Advertising has, of course, always been seen as a superficial exercise, more involved with surface and style than anything else. But the point at issue is the changing content and tone of advertising, the move away from the simple and direct selling of a product on the basis of its value to the consumer, whatever the visual style and trick effects used. Although the intention is still to sell, it is contended that nowadays the postmodern effect is achieved by seemingly overt efforts within advertising to undermine this purpose. Once Guinness was supposed to be good for us and the advert told us so. Now this is much less clear and the adverts are more obscure and less obviously relevant to the product in question. Postmodern adverts are more concerned with the cultural representations of the advert than any qualities the product advertised may have in the outside world, a trend in keeping with the supposed collapse of 'reality' into popular media culture. The stylish look of advertisements, their clever quotations from popular culture and art, their mini sagas, their concern with the surfaces of things, their jokey quips at the expense of advertising itself, their self-conscious revelation of the nature of advertisements as media constructions, and their blatant recycling of the past, are all said to be indicative of the emergence of postmodernism in television advertising.

Pop music

From the point of view of postmodern theory, the recent history of popular music can be seen to be marked by a trend towards the open and extensive mixing of styles and genres of music in very direct and self-conscious ways.¹⁴ This has ranged from the straightforward remixing of already recorded

songs from the same or different eras on the same record, to the quoting and 'tasting' of distinct musics, sounds and instruments in order to create new sub- and pan-cultural identities. Good examples include eclectic successions of pop and rock-'n'-roll records, mixing, collage constructions, reggae sound systems, rap, house, hip hop and techno. It is also necessary to include in this category the so-called 'art rock' musical innovations and mixing of styles associated with groups and performers such as Talking Heads, Laurie Anderson and the Pet Shop Boys.

Whatever the respective merits of these new departures, these examples can be argued to be postmodern. They are concerned with collage, pastiche and quotation, with the mixing of styles which remain musically and historically distinct, with the random and selective pasting together of different musics and styles, with the rejection of divisions between serious and fun or pop music, and with the attack on the idea of rock as a serious artistic music which merits the high cultural accolade of the respectful concert (an attack closely associated with punk). By contrast, 'modernist' popular music can be understood as an attempt to fashion new and distinct forms out of previous styles. So what was distinctive about rock-'n'-roll, for example, was not the fact that it, too, borrowed from and based itself upon already existing musical styles, but that it used these styles to construct something new. Rock-'n'-roll, it is commonly suggested, arose out of the cross-cutting influences exerted by country and western, on the one hand, and urban rhythm and blues, on the other. The result was not, it is argued, a postmodern amalgam in which country and rhythm and blues stayed recognisably the same, but a novel and original fusion called rock-'n'-roll. Similarly with soul music. This is said to have arisen out of the coming together of gospel and blues within black American culture. Yet again the consequence was said to be something strikingly new and different, not a sound which maintained the relatively separate identities of gospel and blues. Put very simply and crudely, the argument about the transition

between modernism and postmodernism in pop music can be seen as a movement from rock-'n'-roll in the late 1950s, and the Beatles, Tamla Motown, Bob Dylan and folk rock in the 1960s, to music mixing, house, hip hop, 'art rock' and 'straight' pop in the 1980s.

The emergence of postmodernism

So far, the meaning of the term postmodernism and indications of its presence in some leading examples of popular media culture have been outlined. Just how extensive and general these indications are, however, is something which is questioned below. Before that we need to look at another aspect of postmodern theory. This is its understanding of the social and historical conditions under which postmodernism is supposed to have emerged.¹⁵

Consumerism and media-saturation

Postmodernism has links with some long-standing arguments about how the scale and effects of consumerism and media-saturation have been vital aspects of the modern development of industrial, capitalist societies. One illustration of this is the attempt to account for the emergence of postmodernism by the claim that during the twentieth century, the economic needs of capitalism have shifted from production to consumption. This suggests that the major need of capitalist societies was to establish their conditions of production. The machines and factories for the manufacturing of goods had to be built and continually updated; heavy industries concerned with basic materials, such as iron and steel, and energy, had to be fostered; the infrastructure of a capitalist economy—roads, rail, communications, education, a welfare state, etc.—had to be laid down; and the workforce had to be taught the 'work ethic', the discipline required by industrial labour. All this meant that consumption had to be sacrificed to the needs of production.

Once a fully functioning system of capitalist production has been established, however, the need for consumption begins to grow, and people need to acquire a leisure or consumer ethic in addition to a work ethic. It would be simple minded to suggest that consumption is only a fairly recent development in the history of capitalism or that the problems of capitalist production have necessarily been resolved. But the point being made is that in an advanced capitalist society such as Britain, the need for people to consume has become as important, if not strategically more important, than the need for people to produce. Increased affluence and leisure time, and the ability of major sections of the working class to engage in certain types of conspicuous consumption, have in their turn served to accentuate this process. Hence, the growth of consumer credit, the expansion of agencies such as advertising, marketing, design and public relations, encouraging people to consume, and the emergence of a postmodern popular culture which celebrates consumerism, hedonism and style.

In this process, the media obviously become more important. The rise of modern mass communications, and the associated proliferation of popular media culture, therefore become central to the explanatory framework of postmodern theory. What is inferred from this is that the mass media have become so significant for communication and information flows within and between modern societies (and consequently the popular culture they broadcast and promote increasingly defines and channels everyday life in these societies) that they, along with consumerism, have given rise to the characteristic features of postmodernism described above. The world, it is argued, will consist more and more of media screens and popular cultural images—TVs, VDUs, videos, computers, computer games, personal stereos, adverts, theme parks, shopping malls, 'fictitious capital' or credit—which are part and parcel of the trends towards postmodern popular culture.

New middle-class occupations

Consumerism and media-saturation have been conceived of as over-abstract processes, but they can be given some social grounding if changes in the class and occupational structures are taken into consideration.¹⁶ From this point of view, the increasing importance of consumption and the media in modern societies has given rise to new occupations (or changed the role and character of older ones) involved with the need to encourage people to consume, more frequently, a greater number and variety of commodities. The idea here is that some groups have to be held responsible for producing postmodernism, however unaware they may be about what they are doing. Hence it can be suggested that certain 'postmodern' occupations have emerged which function to develop and promote postmodern popular culture. These occupations involve the construction of postmodernism. They are claimed to be both creating and manipulating or playing with cultural symbols and media images so as to encourage and extend consumerism. This argument tries to account for the growing importance of occupations such as advertising, marketing, design, architecture, journalism and television production, others such as accountancy and finance associated with increased consumer credit, and those such as social work, therapists of one kind or another, teachers, lecturers and so on, associated with the definition and selling of notions of psychological and personal fulfilment and growth. All these occupations are said to be among the most important in determining the taste patterns for the rest of the society. They exert an important influence over other people's life-styles and values or ideologies (while expressing their own as well).

These new middle-class occupations, which cater for the variety of consumer markets already existing or in the process of being formed, are crucial to the development of a postmodern popular culture. They entail being conversant with the media and popular culture, both of which have to be used and manipulated in order for their appropriate occupational work to be carried out. This is further linked to

the proposition that the cultural ideologies and identities of these occupational groups are becoming increasingly postmodern. At least, certain significant sections within these groups can be described in this way. The nature of the work they carry out and the need to distinguish themselves as a status group from others in the hierarchy of taste both help their elaboration of a postmodern ideology and lifestyle. Their quest for cultural power leads them towards postmodernism and away from the cultures of other classes, such as the high culture of the traditional middle-class intelligentsia.¹⁷

The erosion of identity

The interpretation of identity has become a key issue in the debates raised by postmodern theory.¹⁸ The specific claims that have been made about identity in these debates furnish us with another set of reasons for the emergence of postmodernism. The overall case that can be examined here does not claim that a simple process of decline has occurred but that a limited and dependable set of coherent identities have begun to fragment into a diverse and unstable series of competing identities. The erosion of once secure collective identities has led to the increasing fragmentation of personal identities. It is argued that we have witnessed the gradual disappearance of traditional and highly valued frames of reference in terms of which people could define themselves and their place in society, and so feel relatively secure in their personal and collective identities. These traditional sources of identity—social class, the extended and nuclear family, local communities, the ‘neighbourhood’, religion, trade unions, the nation state—are said to be in decline as a result of tendencies in modern capitalism such as increasingly rapid and wide-scale rates of social change. Economic globalisation, for example, the tendency for investment, production, marketing and distribution to take place on an international basis above and beyond the nation state or the local community, is seen as an important reason for the gradual erosion of these traditional sources of identity.

Transnational economic processes erode the significance of local and national industries and, thereby, the occupational, communal and familial identities they could once sustain.

This argument then goes on to suggest that these problems are exacerbated because no equivalent and workable forms emerge which can take the place of traditional sources of identity. No new institutions or beliefs arise to give people a secure and coherent sense of themselves, the times in which they live and their place in society. Those features of contemporary societies which are novel or which represent the prominence of previously secondary trends, such as the demands of consumerism or watching television, are not thought to offer satisfactory and worthwhile alternatives. In fact, they encourage the features associated with postmodernism. Consumerism by its very nature is seen to foster a self-centred individualism which disrupts the possibilities for solid and stable identities. Television has similar effects because it is both individualistic and universal. People relate to television purely as individual viewers cut off from wider and more genuine social ties, while television relates back to people as individual and anonymous members of an abstract and universal audience. In both cases, the wider collectivities to which people might belong, and the legitimate ideas in which they might believe, tend to be ignored, eroded or fragmented. Neither consumerism nor television form genuine sources of identity and belief, but since there are no dependable alternatives, popular culture and the mass media come to serve as the only frames of reference available for the construction of collective and personal identities.

The limits of postmodernism

This survey of the emergence of postmodernism within contemporary popular culture is not extensive, but it is clearly possible to find examples which clarify the claims of postmodernist theory. We can now question these claims. There are at least two ways to do this: one will be to take a critical look at some of the central arguments of postmodern

theory; the other will be to examine critically the claims it makes about a particular area of popular culture.

First of all, the idea that the mass media take over 'reality' clearly exaggerates their importance. The mass media are important, but not that important. This idea that the media are all important sometimes seems to be merely an ideology which expresses the interests of media professionals. It has less to commend it as a serious analysis because it fails to identify the precise character of this importance, and does not provide empirical evidence for the claims it makes. It also ignores the point that other factors, such as work and the family, contribute to the construction of 'reality'. The related idea that popular media culture regulates consumption rests upon unsubstantiated assumptions about people's behaviour as consumers. Equally, it fails to recognise how useful the commodities which people buy are for them, and neglects the fact that the ability to consume is restricted by economic and cultural inequalities. Moreover, the notion that 'reality' has imploded inside the media such that it can only be defined by the media is equally questionable. Most people would still be able to distinguish between the 'reality' created by the media, and that which exists elsewhere. Of course, if reality has really 'imploded' into the media, how would we know it has happened? We could only rely on the media to tell us that it had, but why should we trust them?

Those theorists who think postmodernism is emerging seem to be echoing many of the anxieties and fears expressed much earlier by mass culture and Frankfurt School critics.¹⁹ This is evident in a number of the arguments put forward by postmodern theory. For example, the ideas that collective and personal identities are being eroded, that modern popular culture is a trash culture, that art is under threat and that the enlarged role of the mass media allows them to exercise a powerful ideological influence over their audiences, all provide clear evidence for this point. Neither are cultural pessimism, and concern over working-class consumption, new issues; nor is the implied distinction between a modernist past

when the world was a better place to live in, and the postmodern present and future when things can only go on getting worse and worse. Not only is too much significance given to consumerism and the power of media such as television, but the claims that are made are rarely substantiated by any evidence. In addition, little attention is given to such things as the nature of people's daily lives, popular attitudes towards consumption, the continuity of identities and the possibility of alternative identities emerging in the course of time.

Another major difficulty with postmodernism lies in its assumption that metanarratives are in decline. In the first place, what is postmodernism, after all, if it is not another metanarrative? It presents a definite view of knowledge and its acquisition, together with a general account of the significant changes it sees occurring in modern societies. It presumes to tell us something true about the world, and knows why it is able to do this. It is therefore difficult to see why postmodernism should not be thought of as a metanarrative. If it is indeed another metanarrative, how can metanarratives be in decline? It could be suggested that postmodernism is the last of the metanarratives. But would it be possible to argue this except on the basis of another metanarrative, since it involves making a claim to know something? It would seem that, far from metanarratives being in decline, they are something we cannot do without. And if, despite its protestations, postmodernism is a metanarrative, there is no reason why we should discard other metanarratives such as Marxism and modernism.

It is apparent that developments in technology and communications have had significant effects on the speed with which information, images and people can be transported around the world. They are therefore in line with postmodernist claims about space and time. As a result, the sense that people now have of time and space must have changed when compared with previous generations. But again the opportunities to experience these changes may be

unequally distributed. They may be more available to some classes and occupational groups than to others. Moreover, why should these changes be qualitatively distinct from those associated with the invention of the aeroplane and the cinema? We need to know about the history within which these changes can be understood, and not succumb to a surprisingly positivistic faith in technology. If we are going to talk about changes, then we must presumably engage in some kind of historical evaluation. Another reason to be sceptical of the claims of postmodern theory is that the effects of these dramatic changes in time and space upon people's lives remain relatively unexamined, the changes in people's consciousness seemingly being assumed to follow automatically from technological changes.

Postmodernist claims about the breakdown of the distinction between art and popular culture have a degree of plausibility, particularly since they seem to relate to the practices and ideologies of certain occupational groups. However, the claims appear to be largely confined to these groups. There are, in fact, a number of difficulties with the idea that such a breakdown is occurring. First, if art and popular culture can still be distinguished from each other, then how far can the breakdown be said to have gone? Second, postmodern culture has been distinguished from other types of culture such as pre-modern and modern. Therefore the possibility of using criteria to distinguish between cultural products does not disappear with postmodernism. If we take the postmodern argument at face value, the potential for cultural discrimination must remain under postmodernism. Otherwise, how can postmodernism be distinguished from other types of culture? Third, the postmodern popular culture produced by certain occupational groups within the cultural industries is clearly not just concerned with a celebratory populism or a know-nothing relativism. The quotes and references that are part of this process are meant to appeal to those 'clever' enough to spot the source of the quote or reference. Rather than dismantling the hierarchy of aesthetic

and cultural taste, postmodernism erects a new one, placing itself at the top. Last, it can be argued that most people do discriminate in their cultural consumption and appreciation, even if they do not do so in order to conform with the demands of the hierarchy of art and mass culture, or of postmodernism.

If we look at the examples of popular culture discussed above, there appear to be changes in the direction of postmodernism, most notably in the areas of architecture and advertising. However, this conclusion is not true of most areas of popular culture. In particular, its relevance to an account of changes in the cinema is limited, as we can show by looking briefly at this example. No doubt there are aspects of contemporary cinema which can be called postmodern, but a number of significant problems emerge if the history of cinema is taken into consideration.²⁰ The changes which are called postmodern are either not as novel as is claimed or are simply misunderstood.

Popular cinema has always been concerned with presenting spectacle to a large audience. From the start, cinema appealed to audiences on the basis of the spectacular events it brought to the screen. To say that postmodernism is concerned with spectacle is to forget this history and to misunderstand the nature of cinema. Obviously, the spectacles screened today are different from those at the turn of the century in their technical achievements. None the less, despite these different technical and cultural contexts, there is no reason to suppose that one era has been more concerned with spectacle than another. Furthermore, stories remain an important aspect of the appeal of contemporary cinema. The *Back to the Future* films may exemplify postmodern claims about confusions over time and space but they are equally held together by effective and complex narratives. Likewise, a spectacular film such as *Blade Runner* has a story about the misguided attempts by science to replicate human life, and the tragic fates its 'replicants' suffer, a theme which goes back to Mary Shelley's *Frankenstein* novel.

From the postmodern point of view, contemporary cinema indulges in nostalgia, living off its past, ransacking it for ideas, recycling its images and plots and cleverly alluding to it in self-conscious postmodern parodies. This view also means that postmodern popular culture is identifiable by its self-conscious awareness of its status as a cultural product. Yet again, this exaggerates the novelty of these developments and misinterprets their character and their history. The repeat and the sequel have been part of the way cinema has worked from its earliest stages. Initially it made use of other types of popular culture such as the stage, the newspaper and the novel, and very soon these media fed off each other for ideas and stories. As it grew, cinema remade films that had been made before. For example, that model of narrative realism *The Maltese Falcon* (1941) was in fact the third film to be made from Hammett's original novel, while between 1908 and 1920 six film versions of Robert Louis Stevenson's *Dr Jekyll and Mr Hyde* were released (Maltin 1991; Wood 1988). Similarly, the history of cinema throws up numerous examples of the film sequel, including those which involved a whole series of repeats. The *Sherlock Holmes* (1922–1985), *Tarzan* (1918–1989) and *Thin Man* (1934–1947) series are obvious examples, but even a cursory survey will reveal a number of other cases (Maltin 1991). Similarly, *King Kong* (1933) spawned *Son of Kong* (1933) and *Mighty Joe Young* (1949). It is also an example of a film which reflects self-consciously upon its status as a cultural product because it deals directly with film-making and spectacle (Kawin 1986).

Insofar as it is possible to generalise, film genres can be said to depend upon a delicate blend of repetition and surprise. As Neale has argued, the historically variable character of genres, the mixing together of genres, the difficulty of allocating particular films to specific genres, together with the confused or hybrid nature of film genres as a whole, are all features to be found throughout the history of cinema rather than being unique to recent films (Neale 1990). Similarly, the parody of genres has a much longer history than is allowed for by

postmodern theory, as does the period film which tries to reconstruct an earlier period of history in a highly stylised manner. Westerns and gangster films readily come to mind as relevant examples in this context. Neither is what postmodern theory has to say about nostalgia films, those films said to be parasitic on the past history of cinema, that convincing.²¹ There are clearly films which can be called nostalgia films. But many films which are evaluated in this way seem to be more importantly concerned with reinventing and reviving genres, and establishing their contemporary relevance, than with repeating what has gone before. For example, *Body Heat* (1981) is sometimes seen as a nostalgia film but, far from merely recycling the past, it is a film which tries to update cinematic images and themes about sex, desire and fate.

This discussion has tried to indicate some of the difficulties confronted by postmodernism and its interpretation of modern cinema. The signs of postmodernism in certain areas of contemporary popular culture may well be quite partial and specific. It is reasonable to suppose that an examination of other areas will reveal problems similar to those arising from this brief survey of cinema. While it cannot be dismissed completely, postmodernism seems subject to severe theoretical and empirical limitations. It is certainly inadequate as a basis for developing a sociology of popular culture.

Some recent theoretical developments

This concluding section of the chapter deals with some of the fallout from postmodernism. Along with, and following on from postmodern theory, there have been a number of recent attempts to analyse popular culture, and we can now look at one or two examples.

Discourse and popular culture

So far, post-structuralism has only been mentioned in passing, mainly because it has not been that directly involved in the analysis of popular culture. However, there are one or two

signs that theorists and researchers working in this area are turning to some of its ideas for new ways of interpreting popular culture. In particular, the work of Michel Foucault (1926–1984), the French post-structuralist philosopher and historian of ideas, whose ideas are central to the critique of structuralism and Marxism, has been used for this purpose, and we can consider briefly one study to assess critically the arguments involved in this perspective.²²

Foucault's ideas have become increasingly prominent in the social sciences, but their impact is much less evident in the sociology of popular culture and the mass media. However, one study which indicates what the application of post-structuralism to this area involves is Ang's attempt to use Foucault's notion of discourse to analyse the audience.²³ For Foucault, discourses are particular ways of organising knowledge in the context of serving specific types of power relationships.

Ang's analysis looks at institutional discourses about television audiences. These audiences do not exist naturally, nor can they be taken for granted. Rather they are constructed by particular discourses which seek to know them in order to exert power over them. For example, advertisers define audiences as consumers, and gather knowledge about their purchasing habits, because they want to sell commodities to them. However, because audiences are constructed in this manner by the combination of knowledge and power within these discourses, it does not mean that real audiences will behave in the way such discourses think they will. Audiences can also be understood by the way they resist the discursive powers which try to construct them in ways these powers want.

Basing her critique upon Foucault's ideas, Ang writes:

in Foucault's work...we find a...detailed emphasis upon the way in which power and knowledge are intertwined through concrete discursive practices—that is, situated practices of functional language use and meaning

production. In these discursive practices, elusive fields of reality are transformed into discrete objects to be known and controlled at the same time. But this can only happen in specific, powerladen institutional contexts, that delimit the boundaries of what can actually be said. More concretely, it is only in and through the discourses that express the institutional point of view that the dispersed realities of audiencehood come to be known through the single, unitary concept of 'television audience'.... But what should be stressed is that the move towards more scientific ways of knowing the audience within television institutions is not simply a sign of progress from ignorance to knowledge... Rather, what is at stake here is a politics of knowledge. In the way television institutions know the audience, epistemological issues are instrumental to political ones: empirical information about the audience such as delivered by audience measurement could become so important only because it produces a kind of truth that is more suitable to meet a basic need of the institutions: the need to control.

(1991:8 and 10)

Ang considers how the major television institutions involved in the organisation, production and communication of programmes operate to control their audiences by treating them as objects of discourses. They construct, produce and distribute knowledge about their audiences so as to control them in keeping with their institutional requirements. The ideas and habits of which television watching is composed are so complex and varied that they have to be defined by the discourses of television institutions if they are to be managed and controlled. According to Ang, the domination of these discourses has meant that the real or ordinary television audience has not figured as prominently as it should have in analyses and discussions of watching television. These discourses speak on behalf of, but not for, the television

audience. By exposing the discourses of the audience developed by the powerful television institutions, discourses which have also influenced academic studies of the audience, she hopes to shift attention back to the ordinary television viewer. To achieve this, it is necessary for research to look at 'the social world of actual audiences', and 'to develop forms of knowledge about television audiencehood that move away from those informed by the institutional point of view' (ibid.: 12).

This understanding of how media organisations work contrasts with the way Marxism treats them as either channels for a dominant ideology or expressions of the demands of profitability. In Ang's analysis, they work according to a much more general drive to exercise power, although in practice there is no reason why it cannot incorporate the arguments of other approaches. Ang tries to substantiate her argument by examining commercial and public service television in America and Europe. However, her use of the concept of power remains vague, abstract and diffuse, general problems encountered by the Foucauldian concept. If television institutions seek to control audiences by discursive forms of knowledge, what are the particular reasons which make them do this? Is there a universal drive to exercise power which characterises all institutions? Or are there more specific social and historical reasons to explain why this should happen, such as the demands of profitability and the constraints of the commodity form? Although Ang does provide evidence of the latter, a theory of this process still needs to suggest the interests which motivate power. Similarly, why should the power of institutions be resisted? What are the interests which motivate resistance to discursive power?

What is more, there is a tendency for this approach to see everything as being discursively constructed, a problem made more acute by the notorious imprecision of the concept of discourse itself. Despite itself, this argument seems usually to end up with nothing but discourses. The realities of power are then dissolved into discourses. For example, Ang suggests that

to confront the institutional construction of audiences it is necessary to consider 'the social world of actual audiences'. However, this is, in its turn, another discursive construction, although preferable to the former: 'we cannot presume to be speaking with the authentic voice of the "real audience", because there is no such thing' (ibid.: 165).

None of us may be able to speak for an authentic audience, but there must be audiences somewhere outside discourses. If the institutional discourses of television audiences are empirically inadequate, how can we know this except by claiming to know why they are inadequate? We don't have to refer to other discursive constructions but to the process of acquiring empirical knowledge. Ang accepts that institutional and academic knowledge about audiences is not completely useless (for example, ibid.: 11), but how can this claim be substantiated if all knowledge is discursively constructed and we can never produce knowledge about real audiences? In fact, the claim which is made can only be based upon some criterion which can distinguish between knowledge which is more useful and that which is less useful, and so between truth and falsehood. Also, is Ang presenting us with just another discourse which we can ignore; or knowledge which will enlighten us about audiences?

The 'dialogical' approach to popular culture

This approach is based upon the dialogue which arises between texts and audiences. Barker has alluded to the potential offered by Foucault's notion of discourse (as 'a specific expression of knowledge as power, as in the way children are "defined" by intelligence and aptitude tests' (1989:220)) for media and cultural studies, and we can treat this approach as an extension of the previous one. He writes of Foucault: 'his way of thinking about power has great potential, and has opened the way to new kinds of research' (ibid.: 213). This potential lies in how Foucault's concept of power shows

the way we can be turned into objects to be studied. Our talk becomes a symptom, our dreams, thoughts, and sensations become the property of 'experts'. That is power. It is not to deny that there are forms of direct physical control, punishment, armies, police forces. But the first and most common form of power lies in these linkings of power/ knowledge.

(ibid.)

However, Barker's mentors are also Volosinov and Propp as well as Foucault. He presents an extensive empirical and critical account of theories which have tried to analyse comics as a form of popular culture. As a result of the failings he notes in these other theories, he puts forward an approach to popular culture which owes much, as he acknowledges, to Volosinov's idea of dialogical analysis.²⁴

The objective of Barker's book is to develop a theory of ideology which does not contain the deficiencies of previous theories, and which can provide an adequate basis for the analysis of comics. To this end, he combines Volosinov's dialogical approach and Propp's emphasis on the importance of narrative forms into a conceptual framework which also owes a small debt to Foucault (ibid.: chapter 12).²⁵ His argument has much in common with that put forward by Frazer (1987), although, rather than turning to discourse analysis, he prefers to retain the concept of ideology. Accordingly, he suggests we can understand comics in terms of a 'contract' between the reader and the text, which is based on a dialogue between them. The meaning of the text arises from this social relationship. A good impression of Barker's argument can be gained from the following:

A 'contract' involves an agreement that a text will talk to us in ways we recognise. It will enter into a dialogue with us. And that dialogue, with its dependable elements and form, will relate to some aspect of our lives in our society. ... I have been illustrating the way specific comics offer a contract to some aspect of the social lives

of their readers. ... It is from this that I want to formulate the central hypotheses of the book: (1) that the media are only capable of exerting power over audiences to the extent that there is a 'contract' between texts and audiences, which relates to some specifiable aspect(s) of the audience's social lives; and (2) the breadth and direction of the influence is a function of those socially constituted features of the audience's lives, and comes out of the fulfilment of the contract; (3) the power of 'ideology' therefore is not of some single kind, but varies entirely—from rational to emotional, from private to public, from 'harmless' to 'harmful'—according to the nature of the 'contract'...if all comics, all media, involve a dialogue between text and reader, then to study one side without implicitly assuming the other, would be like listening to one end of a telephone conversation without thinking about the other person's part...we need to understand ideology as dialogical.

(ibid.: 261)

Barker thus bases his analysis of popular culture on the use of the concept of 'dialogue', formulated initially by Volosinov to develop a theory of language and ideology, in order to study the relationship between texts and readers. He tries to overcome the difficulties confronted by previous theories of ideology, and encourage empirical research.

However, if we refer back to our discussions of Foucault, Ang and Frazer, a number of questions can be raised about this approach. First of all, we might ask what part power has to play in the forming of contracts between texts and audiences since power is supposedly so important for discourse analysis? Can this relationship be regarded as a reasonably equal one? Or if not, what are the bases of the inequalities within which it is shaped? No doubt Barker's notion of the contract is one way of understanding the relationship between audiences and popular culture. It does not dismiss them as 'cultural dopes', nor does it lapse into a

celebration of their freedom to choose whatever culture they want. But it does need to say more about how the contract is formed and transformed by wider power relations. Related to this is a problem regarding the role of production. Texts are not usually produced by readers, but are the result of industrial and cultural production. What, then, do these processes contribute to the dialogue between text and audience? Barker stresses the importance of studying the production histories of cultural forms which 'summarise the interactions of producers (their purposes, institutional structures, external constraints, relations with creators, writers, artists, etc.), their audiences (traditions of reading, definitions of the medium, etc.) through which the form is produced and reproduced' (ibid.: 275). And his book contains accounts of the production histories of a number of comics. But the roles they play in the dialogues and contracts with which he wishes to analyse popular culture are not fully or consistently discussed. His stress upon the significance of production histories, the structures and transformations of cultural forms, 'the social characteristics of the audience' (ibid.), and the concept of the contract between text and readers, make his argument more substantial and wide-ranging than those offered by either Foucauldian or dialogical theories. But it implies that there may be as many production histories as there are types of popular culture and so gives up on generalising theoretically about production and consumption; and it is still a long way from considering how the relationships he discusses are influenced by the way popular culture becomes a commodity.

Cultural populism

This is defined by McGuigan as follows: 'cultural populism is the intellectual assumption, made by some students of popular culture, that the symbolic experiences and practices of ordinary people are more important analytically and politically than Culture with a capital C' (1992:4). In fact, McGuigan's book is part of a recent critical backlash against

the emergence of a populist approach to the analysis of popular culture. He complains about

a discernable narrowing of vision in cultural studies, exemplified by the drift into an uncritical populist mode of interpretation. I support the wish to understand and value everyday meanings, but, alone, such a wish produces inadequate explanations of the material life situations and power relations that shape the mediated experiences of ordinary people.

(*ibid.*: 244)

For McGuigan, populism understands popular cultural forms as an expression of the interests, experiences and values of ordinary people, and this is precisely what is wrong with it. It becomes an uncritical endorsement rather than a critical dissection of popular culture.

Populism argues that popular culture cannot be understood as a culture which is imposed upon the thoughts and actions of people. Whether this imposition is said to result from the demands of capitalist production and consumption for profits and markets, from the needs of capitalism or patriarchy for ideological control, from the interests of a bourgeois class, from the playing out of the class struggle or from the dictates of an universal mental structure, it is none the less inadequate as a way of understanding popular culture. According to populism, popular culture cannot be understood unless it is viewed, not as an imposition, but as a more or less genuine expression of the voice of the people. The critical response to the mass culture critics' condemnation of the Americanisation of British culture can be cited as an example of populism. From this point of view, the attempt to wrest something positive from American popular culture is not to be dismissed as a slavish and misguided imitation of American life, but welcomed as the assertion of pleasure and creativity in a culture which allows popular participation and celebration for ordinary people. That American popular culture is popular with the British working class is no reason to disregard it, or

to write it off as the imposition of economic and ideological power. For populists, this dismissive attack can be safely left in the hands of middle-class intellectuals. In their eyes, these intellectuals don't realise that not only do they have an inadequate explanation, since it does not take into consideration the wishes and desires of the people, but the very fact that it is associated with intellectuals is reason enough to be suspicious about its status as an argument.

One of the problems with cultural populism, for McGuigan, is that it has become increasingly influential in the study of popular culture. He sees it exemplified by some of the work of the Centre for Contemporary Cultural Studies at Birmingham University on youth subcultures and popular television, as well as by the ideas of Fiske,²⁶ whose views are often taken as perfect illustrations of the claims and limitations of populism (ibid.: 70–75 and chapters 3 and 4). The target of McGuigan's critique is:

an uncritical populist drift in contemporary cultural studies ...[in which] ordinary people use the symbolic resources available to them under present conditions for meaningful activity...thus, emancipatory projects to liberate people from their alleged entrapment, whether they know they are entrapped or not, are called into question.... Economic exploitation, racism, gender and sexual oppression, to name but a few, exist, but the exploited, estranged and oppressed cope...very well... making valid sense of the world and obtaining grateful pleasure from what they receive.

(ibid.: 171)

While he makes a number of criticisms of this perspective, McGuigan's main complaints concern its neglect of the 'macro-processes of political economy', its failure to 'account for both ordinary people's everyday culture and its material construction by powerful forces beyond the immediate comprehension and control of ordinary people', and its complicity with 'economic liberalism's concept of "consumer

sovereignty''' (ibid.: 172, 175 and 176; for a similar critique, see Golding and Murdock 1991: 28; cf. Strinati 2000).

Interestingly enough, the theories discussed in this book do not take a populist position on the role of the audience in their explanations of popular culture. Whether it is defined as a political strategy or an analysis of culture, populism has a long history, as the critique of mass culture theory's attack on Americanisation showed. Yet it is difficult to find in the major theories of popular culture an explicit statement of the populist approach. Even semiology, which is argued to have played a part in the development of the Birmingham Centre's cultural populism, says the audience takes for granted the cultural signs which surround it and fails to perceive the ideological work they are doing.²⁷ Populism has clearly figured in the ideologies of the producers of popular culture as a way of justifying what they produce—'giving people what they want'—and it can equally be an ideology of audiences (Ang 1989). This perhaps suggests that populism is more important as an ideology than it is as a theory. But in view of the generally dismissive attitude taken by a number of theories towards the popular audience, it is perhaps not that surprising if some writers have been prompted to turn to populism as a response to the elitism to be found generally in theories of popular culture.

Ironically enough, populism represents a mirror image of elitism and this shows up its critical failings, for it is basically an overreaction to elitism. Whereas theories have often seen audiences as full of passive unthinking dupes, open to manipulation and ideological control by the mass media and the culture they spread, populism has turned this around, seeing audiences as self-conscious, active subversives, exploiting media culture for their own ends, and resisting and reinterpreting messages circulated by cultural producers. Whereas elitism has patronised the audience by calling it stupid, populism has patronised the audience by calling it subversive. Populism has still presumed to speak on behalf of, not to, audiences. If the elitist conception of the audience is

wrong, then so is the populist one, and for similar reasons. They both operate in terms of unfounded caricatures, and without an adequate empirical and historical appreciation of the social and cultural nature of audiences (cf. Barker 1989).²⁸ Indeed, it is possible to think of the popularity of popular culture as a real sociological problem, without thereby becoming a populist.

Another aspect of this problem is the way populism has prevented a more adequate account of consumption from being included in theorising about popular culture. The critique of populism has equated it with consumption. This has meant that any attempt to understand the role of consumption in determining forms of popular culture has been regarded as another example of populism, and therefore dismissed. This is a feature of the political economy perspective, and is clearly justified by some of the more extreme statements of the populist position. But by concentrating upon those writers who see consumption as a type of populist subversion, exponents of this critique neglect authors such as Bourdieu (1984) and Miller (1987) (cf. Campbell (1987), Moorhouse (1991) and Stacey (1994)), whose discussion of consumption is not at all populist. As Miller notes, for example, remarking upon the critique of consumption to be found in modern social theories such as postmodernism:

these global approaches almost always move from an attack on contemporary material culture as trivial or inauthentic to an implied (though rarely explicit) denigration of the mass of the population whose culture this is. By contrast, the analysis of particular domains of consumption...allows for a more sensitive discrimination between those elements of consumption which appear to generate close social relations and social groupings (such as those among children and neighbourhoods) and those which, by analogy with the critique of ideology, appear to act to prevent sections of the population from

representing their interests, and to suppress any expression of those perspectives which might help to develop such interests.

(1987:16; cf. 10)

It would also be interesting to see how consumption would fit into the political economy approach.²⁹ And while the social sciences have shown relatively little interest in the process of cultural and material consumption (ibid.: 7), Bourdieu's work (1984) might be useful in this context as it tries to connect cultural consumption with cultural production.³⁰

The argument that the major determinant of popular culture is the need for the cultural industries to make a profit is not just an argument about production, or about how and why cultural goods are produced. It is also an argument about consumption, or about how and why the goods produced make a profit by finding large enough markets. The analysis of popular culture requires an emphasis on both, particularly since it is doubtful whether power and control over production by themselves are sufficient to determine patterns of cultural consumption. Apart from anything else, the latter are also an important influence on what gets produced. And it is the combination of production and consumption within the structure of the commodity, rather than an abstract will to power, which may well explain why, for example, television institutions (Ang 1991) produce discourses about their audiences.

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